



THE INSTITUTE OF SPIRITUAL LEARNING

The Quiet Mind

Foundations in Buddhist & Taoist Contemplative Practice

Course Workbook & Personal Meditation Handbook

Five weeks · one core text and one guided practice at a time

How to use this workbook

This workbook is yours to keep — print it and write by hand, or use it alongside the Course Room on the ISL website, where each week's exercise is also saved to your account automatically. Either way, the exercises are the same: one short paragraph a week, each an honest, plain record of what you actually noticed — not a piece of writing for anyone else to judge.

Across the five weeks you will build a personal meditation handbook, one paragraph at a time. In the sixth and final piece, a longer closing contemplation, you will draw those five paragraphs together — and once that is written, you are ready to book your one-to-one tutorial with Benjamin.

Your reading, one book per week

Week 1 — The Dhammapada

Week 2 — The Buddha and His Religion — J. Barthélemy-Saint-Hilaire

Week 3 — Seeking the Heart of Wisdom — Joseph Goldstein & Jack Kornfield

Week 4 — The Tao Te Ching — Lao Tzu

Week 5 — Tao: The Watercourse Way — Alan Watts

WEEK 1

Learning to Sit

Before you study any system of thought, you need a working relationship with your own attention. That is the whole task of this first week — nothing more. Meditation is not a belief system and it asks nothing of you philosophically; it is a discipline of the body and the breath that anyone can practise, whatever they otherwise think is true.

Find a seat — a chair, a cushion, the floor — where your spine can be upright without being rigid. Let your hands rest, let your eyes close or soften toward the floor, and bring your attention to the sensation of breathing: the air moving in, the pause, the air moving out. You will lose the thread almost immediately. That is not failure — noticing that you have wandered, and returning without irritation, is the entire practice.

Sit like this for ten to fifteen minutes once a day through the week. As you do, read a little of the Dhammapada each day — a handful of verses is enough — and let its plain, direct language sit alongside what you are noticing in your own mind.

Two questions to carry with you as you sit and read: what actually happens in the body and mind during sustained, simple attention to breath — where does the mind go, and how does it feel to bring it back? And what does “impermanence” mean when you watch a single breath end and the next begin?

This week's reading

The Dhammapada

The oldest and simplest expression of the Buddha's teaching: short verses on the mind, on suffering, and on the discipline that quiets both. Read slowly — a few verses a day is enough.

Handbook, Paragraph One — What You Noticed

This is the first entry in the personal meditation handbook you will build across the five weeks of this course — a short, honest record you can return to whenever you sit again. In three to six sentences, in your own words, describe what you actually noticed this week: where your attention went, what it felt like to bring it back, and anything that surprised you about ten minutes of stillness. Write for yourself, not for a reader — plain and specific beats eloquent.

WEEK 2

The Shape of the Path

Having spent a week simply sitting, this week gives that practice its context. Barthélemy-Saint-Hilaire's book is old enough now to be a piece of intellectual history in its own right, but it remains an unusually clear introduction to the architecture of the Buddha's teaching: the recognition that dissatisfaction (*dukkha*) is woven through ordinary life, that it arises from craving and clinging, that it can cease, and that there is a specific path — ethical, mental, and contemplative — that leads to its cessation.

Read for the shape of the argument rather than trying to master every term. What matters this week is a single, practical distinction: the difference between non-attachment and indifference. Non-attachment is not about caring less. It is the capacity to be fully present with something — a person, a plan, an outcome — without your peace of mind depending on it turning out a particular way.

Keep sitting daily as you did in week one; you can extend the sit by a few minutes if it feels natural. Notice, this week specifically, moments in ordinary life where you can feel the pull of craving or clinging — wanting something to be different than it is — and notice what changes, if anything, when you simply see that pull clearly instead of acting on it.

Where do Buddhist and Taoist views of the self agree, and where do they diverge? You will meet this question again properly in weeks four and five — for now, simply hold it loosely as you read.

This week's reading

The Buddha and His Religion — J. Barthélemy-Saint-Hilaire

A classic, careful account of the Buddha's life and teaching, written from outside the tradition looking in. Use it to fill in the map: the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, and the shape of the teaching your sitting practice already belongs to.

Handbook, Paragraph Two — Non-Attachment in Practice

Describe one real moment this week when you noticed craving, clinging, or resistance to something being as it was — and what happened, in your mind or your behaviour, once you saw it clearly. If nothing comes to mind, describe instead what non-attachment would have looked like in a recent situation where you didn't notice it at the time. This becomes the second paragraph of your handbook.

WEEK 3

Awareness Off the Cushion

The first two weeks gave you a practice and a map. This week is about depth: taking the simple attention you have been training and turning it into genuine insight — seeing the actual, moment-to-moment nature of experience rather than the story you usually tell about it.

Goldstein and Kornfield write from direct, decades-long experience of teaching this practice to people with no prior background, and the book is unusually good at naming the specific difficulties you will already be running into — restlessness, boredom, judgement of your own practice — and showing how each one is itself something to be met with the same quality of attention, rather than a problem to solve before “real” meditation can begin.

This week, extend the practice beyond the cushion. Choose one ordinary daily activity — washing up, walking somewhere familiar, the first five minutes of a meal — and bring the same quality of full, non-judging attention to it that you have been bringing to the breath. Notice how much of daily life is normally lived on autopilot.

What actually changes in an ordinary action when you are fully present for it, rather than half-thinking about something else? Is there a difference between “concentration” and “awareness” — and which one is closer to what you have been practising?

This week's reading

Seeking the Heart of Wisdom — Joseph Goldstein & Jack Kornfield

A practical guide to insight (vipassana) meditation from two of the most experienced Western teachers of the tradition. It moves the practice from theory into the actual mechanics of a sitting, and into daily life.

Handbook, Paragraph Three — Awareness Off the Cushion

Write about the daily-life activity you chose this week and what you noticed bringing full attention to it. Was it harder or easier than sitting still? What did you learn about how much of your day usually happens without you fully there for it? This is the third paragraph of your handbook.

WEEK 4

Doing Without Forcing

The course now turns from India to China, and from a path of stages to a philosophy of paradox. Where the texts so far have described a path with recognisable steps, the Tao Te Ching resists being reduced to instructions at all. Its central idea, wu wei, is usually translated “non-action,” but is better understood as effortless action — acting in a way so aligned with the actual shape of a situation that it doesn’t feel like forcing anything.

This is not passivity. Water, Lao Tzu’s favourite image, is not still — it is the softest thing there is, and yet it wears away stone, finds the lowest and least glamorous path, and eventually gets everywhere. The strength is in the yielding, not despite it.

As you read, hold your sitting practice up against this. Watch what happens when you try to force stillness during meditation, versus when you simply allow the mind to settle. Notice, too, any place in ordinary life this week where straining to control an outcome made things harder, and where doing less, or doing differently, would have served you better.

Where do Buddhist non-attachment and Taoist wu wei agree, and where do they genuinely diverge? Both ask you to stop forcing outcomes — but is the Buddhist path aimed at a state of mind, and the Taoist path aimed at a way of acting in the world? Sit with the question rather than resolving it too quickly.

This week’s reading

The Tao Te Ching — Lao Tzu

A short, deliberately paradoxical text — eighty-one brief chapters you could read in an evening, though it repays reading slowly across the whole week. It will feel, at first, like a different language from the last three weeks; that difference is the point.

Handbook, Paragraph Four — Doing Without Forcing

Describe a moment this week — in meditation or in ordinary life — where you noticed the difference between forcing something and letting it happen. What did each one actually feel like in your body? This is the fourth paragraph of your handbook.

WEEK 5

Stillness and Flow

This closing week brings the course's two halves — the stillness you cultivated through weeks one to three, and the flow you have been considering through Lao Tzu — into a single image: water, which is still enough to reflect the sky perfectly and moving enough to carve canyons, depending only on what it meets.

Watts writes with unusual clarity about what the Tao actually is: not a force to be obeyed, and not a passive drifting, but the intelligence already present in a natural process working itself out — the way a plant grows toward light without deliberating about it, or a river finds the sea without a map. Your five weeks of sitting practice have been an attempt to let your own mind work the same way: not controlled into stillness by force, but allowed to settle the way water settles when nothing is stirring it.

For your final sitting sessions this week, try dropping the sense of “doing” meditation altogether, and instead simply allow yourself to arrive at stillness, the way water finds its own level. Notice what is different, if anything, about a stillness you arrive at rather than one you construct.

How does “flowing like water” relate to the stillness you have been cultivating all course — are they the same quality seen from two directions, or genuinely different capacities? What, plainly, in your own words, have five weeks of daily practice actually changed in how your attention works?

This week's reading

Tao: The Watercourse Way — Alan Watts

Watts's last book, unfinished at his death and completed from his notes — the most accessible bridge between the Tao Te Ching's poetry and a modern, practical understanding of what it is actually describing.

Handbook, Paragraph Five — Stillness and Flow

In your own words, distil what you now understand about your own attention after five weeks of practice — the relationship, as you have actually experienced it, between stillness and flow. This is the fifth and final weekly paragraph of your handbook.

Closing Contemplation — Preparing for Your Tutorial

Now write a longer closing piece — a page or so, no strict limit — that draws these five paragraphs into one contemplation. You might write about which week's insight has stayed with you most strongly, where you still feel resistance or confusion, what you would want to ask Benjamin directly, or simply what your daily practice now looks like compared to where it started. There is no correct answer being tested here; the aim is to arrive at your tutorial having genuinely thought about what these five weeks were for you, so the conversation can start from something real.

YOUR CLOSING CONTEMPLATION

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